



“There had been no deliberate plan, but in elaborating the aeroplane, and in doing all they could to calm those that flew in it, they had created... the most infernal conditions in which to die.”

JULIAN BARNES

FROM THE NOVEL *STARING AT THE SUN*

DOUGLAS DC-10

All DC-10s were grounded in 1979 after a crash at Chicago killed 271 people. A badly designed cargo door was blamed for another DC-10 accident near Paris in 1974 when 346 people died.



FEAR OF FLYING

STATISTICS PROVE THAT FLYING IS BY FAR THE SAFEST WAY OF TRAVELING LONG DISTANCES, BUT AIR ACCIDENTS INSPIRE A MORBID FASCINATION

THE AIRLINE INDUSTRY has always known that its success depends on convincing the public that air travel is safe. This has never been an easy task. The drama of air disasters impresses itself so intensely on the public consciousness—partly, no doubt, precisely because they are rare—that flying is often inextricably associated in people’s minds with sudden and violent death. Yet measures to reduce the number of air accidents and aviation-related deaths may undermine the image of air travel as a normal, safe, everyday experience. The more safety procedures air

passengers are subjected to, the less secure they are likely to feel. Surely flying cannot be that safe if we are searched before boarding and flight attendants insist on telling us where the oxygen masks and emergency exits are? For the nervous,

